NCP

STAYING PAWAR

By Dhaval Kulkarni



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Sharad Pawar is a political cat with far more than nine lives. His withdrawal of resignation on May 5 as the president of the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) may be seen by many as only a temporary truce within the party, but with that denouement, Pawar has shown who's the boss. His surprise announcement of retirement from the helm of the NCP had come only on May 2. That effectively put an unbridgeable moat around the fortress amid reports that a faction led by Ajit Pawar, his nephew and leader of the Opposition in the Maharashtra assembly, was in talks with the BJP. NCP leaders and workers went into an emotional three-day protest pleading for the return of the party patriarch. And when he did come full circle, it had ring-fenced the NCP.

However, despite Pawar's show of strength, the elephants in the room continue to linger. Has Ajit shelved any plans to align with the BJP or only kept them on the backburner for now? Though Ajit outright denies any covert talks, senior BJP leader and Union minister Narayan Rane has said Ajit was on the "*seemaresha*" (border) of the BJP. Rane claims even the NCP leaders imploring Pawar to take back his resignation were trying to join the BJP.

Sources say Ajit and his camp, which includes a national leader who is said to be in the cross-hairs of the enforcement agencies, are eager to ensure that the NCP breaks away from the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA) to ally with the BJP. Leaders of the MVA's constituents admit that even if they stay together, seat-sharing between three and more parties will be a challenge, especially in the assembly polls.

On his part, for the record, Pawar Sr too denies Ajit is likely to break ranks. He says Ajit's approach revolves around "working on the field"—it's just that "he is not media-friendly". This, he claimed, led to "*gairsamaj*" (misunderstanding). "... there is nothing like this (Ajit joining hands with the BJP)," asserted Pawar, speaking to the media. And his political authority is such that mere words from him can become a silken web.

"Pawar saheb played the game well... He has killed several birds with a stone by showing that he commands the loyalty of the rank and file and by isolating Ajit dada," says an NCP leader. However, another leader who is closer to Ajit points out that Pawar cannot afford to alienate his nephew beyond a point as the latter commands the loyalty of most of the MLAs. "Those who were protesting in Mumbai were specifically from (NCP state unit chief) Jayant Patil's camp. Barring a few MLAs like Patil and Jitendra Awhad, not many from the legislative wing of the party went beyond the usual lip service to persuade Pawar to rethink his resignation," he adds. The NCP leader, however, admits they will have to think twice before advocating any truck with the BJP "considering the passions Pawar's resignation whipped up, especially after he had underlined his role as a major opposition figure who can unite diverse parties to take on the BJP in 2024".

There are indications that Pawar Sr may finally have to strike a truce with his ambitious nephew and cede some ground to him to prevent any erosion in the ranks. While Pawar's daughter and Baramati MP Supriya Sule may get a prominent national role, Ajit may have a greater say in the party affairs in Maharashtra. Sources claim that the role of Patil, a seven-term MLA, with whom Ajit is said to have a running battle, may be circumscribed—he may even be asked to make way for Ajit's nominee.

"Regardless of Pawar withdrawing his resignation, it is almost sure that the NCP will split at some point in the